of serum, urine, etc., It is a very important diagnostic tool to determine if a person is HIV positive or negative. ELISA is a tool for determining serum antibody concentrations (such as the antibodies produced in a person infected by pathogens such as HIV) and also for detecting the presence of specific antigens and hormones such as human chorionic gonadotropins.

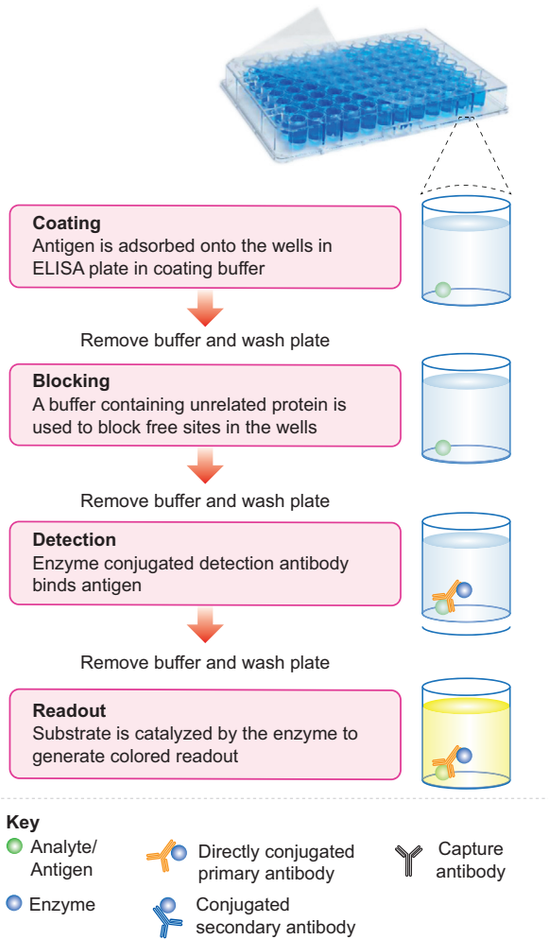


Fig. 10.5 Enzyme Linked Immuno Sorbent Assay

During diagnosis the sample suspected to contain the antigen is immobilized on the surface of an ELISA plate **(Fig. 10.5)**. The antibody specific to this antigen is added and allowed to react with the immobilized antigen. The anti-antibody is linked to an appropriate enzyme like peroxidase. The unreacted anti-antibody is washed away and the substrate of the enzyme (hydrogen peroxide) is added with certain reagents such as 4-chloronaphthol. The activity of the enzyme yields a coloured product indicating the presence of the antigen. The intensity of the colour is directly proportional to the amount of the antigen. ELISA is highly sensitive and can detect antigens in the range of a nanogram.

There are four kinds of ELISA namely, Direct ELISA, Indirect ELISA, sandwich ELISA and competitive ELISA. It is a highly sensitive and specific method used for diagnosis. ELISA possesses the added advantages of not requiring radioisotopes or a radiation counting apparatus.

PCR (Polymerase Chain Reaction)

The polymerase chain reaction (PCR) is an *invitro* amplification technique used for synthesising multiple identical copies (billions) of DNA of interest. The technique was developed by **Kary Mullis** (Nobel laureate, 1993) in the year 1983.

Denaturation, renaturation or primer annealing and synthesis or primer extension, are the three steps involved in PCR **(Fig. 10.6)**. The double stranded DNA of interest is denatured to separate into two individual strands by high temperature . This is called **denaturation**. Each strand is allowed to hybridize with a primer (renaturation or primer annealing). The primer template is used to synthesize DNA by using Taq – DNA polymerase (isolated from the bacterium *Thermus aquaticus*).

During denaturation the reaction mixture is heated to 95^0 C for a short time to denature the target DNA into single strands that will act as a template for DNA synthesis. Annealing is done by rapid cooling of the mixture, allowing the primers to bind to the sequences on each of the two strands flanking the target DNA. During primer extension or

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